Second Chance / No Opt Out

Returning after ‘I don’t know’

Use Second Chance when a student’s first response is “I don’t know” or incomplete. Provide a route to a successful contribution and return to the student.

How to do it well

1 Set the expectation in advance. Explain that an uncertain pupil will receive more thinking time and be asked again after hearing one or two responses.

2 Pause and reframe. Acknowledge the hesitation without blame, state that you will return and give a precise listening task.

3 Invite useful peer responses. Ask one or two pupils for clear answers or reasoning that the original pupil can evaluate—not a long parade of guesses.

4 Return and require retrieval. Ask the original pupil to paraphrase, select the strongest response, explain why or add an idea of their own.

5 Reinforce persistence and improve. Acknowledge that the pupil stayed with the thinking, then give a task-focused prompt that increases precision next time.

What this sounds like

“I will ask two more people, then return to you. Listen for which explanation uses the key term accurately. You will tell us which one you chose and why.”

Classroom example. A pupil cannot initially explain the selected method. The teacher asks the pupil to listen to two alternatives, then returns for a choice and reason. A further related example follows where useful. The return keeps the pupil engaged in thinking while support makes the expected contribution attainable.

Top tips that make the technique work

Signal the return. The student should know they will have another chance and what to listen for.

Give a meaningful listening task. Ask them to select, paraphrase or develop a useful answer rather than repeat sounds mechanically.

Provide help when knowledge is missing. A prompt or model may be necessary before a successful response is possible.

Keep the tone warm. The purpose is continued participation and learning, not exposing hesitation.

Ask for application where appropriate. A further related question can distinguish hearing another answer from understanding the idea.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Return after preparation or support.	Moving on and never returning.
Require an attainable, meaningful contribution.	Repeatedly demanding an answer without giving access to it.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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